

Button or touch

These days it is all about touch with touch-screen devices and smartwatches are not far behind. Needless to say, a touch-screen display is easier to navigate. But, for those who are not comfortable with these and find targeting items on a small screen difficult, makers like Pebble have heard them and have created products where majority of scrolling is done using physical buttons. Moreover, smartwatches with touch-screens are comparatively more expensive than the ones with physical buttons. But over a period of time, touch-screen based smartwatches are poised to win, provided these are able to offer good aesthetics and the simplicity of physical buttons.

Display and style

When it comes to style, choosing a smartwatch is no different from choosing a regular watch. The first thing a user must look at is comfort, as the device has to be worn daily. The strap and body of a smartwatch plays a crucial role here. People who do not want to get rid of their traditional choices may like a slimmer smartwatch with straps made of leather or stainless steel. However, most smartwatches these days feature a flexible silicon strap, which is a good choice for people engaged in outdoor activities.

Coming to the display of smartwatches, there are a variety of options to choose from. Ranging from organic light emitting diode (OLED) and active-matrix organic light emitting diode (AMOLED) displays to LCDs, you can choose one depending on your requirement and budget. While OLED and AMOLED technologies can work without a backlight and consume less power, LCD displays use backlights to produce images on screens. LCD displays deliver better performance in brighter environment, like that in sunlight.

For those who are power conscious and want batteries to last for a long time, a black-and-white display is a good choice. These displays, with E Ink or E Paper technologies, too offer better views in bright environment.

Of course, like in smartphones, choosing a chemically-strengthened and waterproof/water-resistant glass adds to the life of the smartwatch.

Notifications

Any smartwatch displays notifications of your phone/tablet, like incoming calls, text messages, emails and alarms. If you actively use social media, you can check if the smartwatch of your choice provides social media notifications or not. This will make your life much easier.

Also, look for customisation options when it comes to displaying notifications. Most of the smartwatches available today allow customisation for notifications, allowing users to choose which notifications to display. Some smartwatches display notifications with just icons, while others display the entire message. So make your choice keeping in mind the level of privacy you want.

Some smartwatches also allow users to make and receive calls, like in the case of Bluetooth headsets. This might cost a little more, so we suggest you evaluate your options before making an investment.

Apps and special features

Let us talk about apps. Since it is a new product, there is not much interest from developers so far. Smartwatches really do not have a great app ecosystem around. However, as mentioned earlier, this is poised to change soon. Pebble, which has two smartwatch offerings in the market, has over 3200 apps to offer, but both models from the company can store only eight apps each at a time. Android Wear is also in the stage of development, when it comes to offering apps. There are very few apps optimised for the platform.

However, smartwatches offer a lot of special features that can make the lives of their users easier. Please note that these special features may vary in different devices. Some popular smartwatch features include fitness and activity trackers, cameras, link alarm and music. ●

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Website: www.shavison.com
Email: shavison@shavison.com

SHAVISON ELECTRONICS PVT. LTD.

Unit No. G-5, B Wing, Udyog Bhavan No. 2, Plot K-3,
Anand Nagar MIDC, Ambarnath (E) 421 506, MH, India.
TeleFax: +91-251-2620417/2620427 Cell: +91 98 203 62980

Ahmedabad : Integrated-0982570965 Ahmednagar : Tech Edge Controls - 0982012595
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